

THE SPORTSCAST

by Underdawgs

Plain-Language Project Guide

What we've built, why it's built this way, and where it's going.

Written 2026-07-09 · for anyone joining the project without a technical background

1. What We're Actually Building

Underdawns is the parent company. It's a small, founder-run group building a handful of separate ventures — this media outlet, and other things down the line like “The Rabbitat” and “A Million Bees.” Underdawns owns and produces these things; it isn't the brand customers see first.

This project is **The Sportscast** — the flagship media outlet. On purpose, the name customers see everywhere is “The Sportscast,” big and bold. “by Underdawns” appears only as a small credit line, the way a movie studio's logo is small at the start of a trailer. If anyone ever suggests making the Underdawns name bigger or more prominent than The Sportscast, that goes against a decision that's been made and re-confirmed more than once — check before changing it.

The core idea: an archive, not a news feed

This is the single most important thing to understand about the whole project. In the founder's own words: *“we are not bombarding everyone with every news but creating a true archive for every story, where we can look back, track impact and even follow up.”*

In practice, that means:

- The website is deliberately calm and uncluttered — not a busy homepage stuffed with the latest headlines.
- The real way people engage isn't by reading article after article — it's through **Shows**: one flagship long conversation (also called “The Sportscast”) plus five shorter, sport-specific weekly shows. These get posted as short clips on social media and full-length on YouTube.
- Written stories still exist, but they live in a section called **The Archive** — a permanent, browsable record, not a feed competing for your attention.

If a future idea sounds like “let's add a news ticker” or “let's show more headlines on the homepage,” stop and reconsider first. That instinct has come up before in this project and was deliberately designed against.

2. How the Website Is Actually Built

The website is built simply, on purpose. There's no complicated app-building framework underneath it — it's built with plain web pages and a small, lightweight program that serves them up and stores the content. Think of it less like a piece of complex software and more like a well-organized filing system with a front desk.

Why this matters: it means one or two people can understand the *entire* system without specialized training on a big framework. That's a deliberate choice to match how the company is run — a lean, founder-led operation, not a large engineering team. Anyone extending this project should keep that same simplicity in mind rather than bringing in heavy, complicated tools.

The one thing that trips people up: the homepage is a special case

The homepage was built first, before the rest of the site's shared style rules existed. Because of that, it keeps its own separate copy of the visual styling instead of sharing the same one every other page uses. In plain terms: if someone changes a color or a font on the rest of the site, they have to remember to make the same change twice — once for the homepage, once for everywhere else. This is a known quirk, not a mistake to silently "fix" without checking first, since it's set up this way for a reason (it was simply built earlier).

Getting it running

The technical steps live in the code itself, but in plain terms: install the small set of tools it depends on, set up a fresh local copy of the story database, load in some sample content, and start the local server. A developer picking this up will find exact commands in the code.

3. The Look and Feel (Brand System)

There's a separate, more detailed document ("The Underdawns Visual Code") that governs the whole company's logos and visual identity, not just this website. This section covers what's actually built into the site today.

Colors

The palette is gold, brown, black, and white — pulled from the original Underdawns bulldog logo's coloring. **There is deliberately no red anywhere in the brand.** Red was removed on purpose once the visual identity was formalized. There's one narrow exception: a muted red is still used strictly for error messages (like an invalid form entry) and for flagging "disputed" information — that's a universal design convention for warning people something's wrong, not a brand color, and it should stay that way.

The logo

"THE SPORTSCAST" is the big, bold name. "by Underdawns" floats as a small tag above the top-right corner of it — almost like a trademark symbol. This exact placement was tested a few different ways (stacked underneath, stacked above-and-to-the-left, floating at the corner) and the floating corner version is the one that was chosen after comparing them side by side. If a written style guide elsewhere describes it differently, the website itself is the up-to-date version — the guide document needs updating to match, not the other way around.

Fonts

Two typefaces: a bold, condensed, all-caps style for headlines and show names, and a plain, easy-to-read style for body text and navigation.

4. How Content Is Organized

Every piece of content on the site — whether it's a written feature story or a video episode — is stored the same underlying way, just with a few small settings that determine what it actually is and where it shows up:

- A setting decides whether it's a written article or a video episode.
- A setting decides which sport it's about (football, rugby, etc.).
- For video episodes, a setting decides which **Show** it belongs to — this single setting is the entire mechanism that makes the six different shows work. There's no separate, more complicated system behind the scenes for “Shows” — it's just this one label.
- Content can also be labeled with simple tags like Feature, Analysis, Interview, or Transfers.

5. Shows vs. Sports — A Distinction Worth Understanding

These sound similar but mean different things, and mixing them up causes confusion:

- **A Show** is a packaging decision — think of it as a TV channel's lineup. It's what you'd put on a YouTube thumbnail or pitch to a sponsor. There are six, fixed: The Sportscast (the flagship, covering everything), The Hydration Break (football), The Ruck (rugby), Bully Off (hockey), Fast Break (basketball), and The Circuit (athletics, boxing, martial arts, and darts — deliberately bundled into one show).
- **A Sport** is simply a data label, kept more detailed than the shows. Boxing, martial arts, and darts each get their own separate sport label even though they all appear under one show (The Circuit) — otherwise it would be impossible to search for or track boxing content specifically.

Each show also has its own accent color used throughout the site: gold for the flagship, green for football, teal for rugby, blue for hockey, brown for basketball, and purple for The Circuit.

6. Photos on the Site

There's a simple system for adding real photos: drop a photo file in a specific, clearly-named spot, and it shows up automatically — no need to touch any code. If a photo hasn't been added yet for a particular spot, the site gracefully falls back to a simpler placeholder design instead of looking broken.

Honest status check: the flagship show, the homepage, and two of the five smaller shows (football and rugby) currently have real, correctly-matched photos — actual event and team photos, not stock imagery. The other three shows (hockey, basketball, and the combined athletics/combat/darts show) currently have real photos too, but they're *not actually photos of those sports* — they're placeholder rugby-event photos used temporarily because they were the only real photos available at the time. They're meant to be swapped out once proper photos exist.

A recurring annoyance worth knowing about: phone photos often get saved sideways, and there's no reliable way to predict which direction to rotate them — it varies from photo to photo, even from the same phone on the same day. Always double check a photo looks right after adding it.

7. A Feature We Removed On Purpose

Until recently, this website was connected to a separate, second piece of software — a standalone player and club database (nicknamed “Underdoggs Data”) — to show things like team rosters, player profiles, and transfer news. That connection has been fully removed.

The reasoning: The Sportscast should be a **purely media outlet** — articles, shows, and the archive — without depending on a second, separate piece of software just to keep running. Maintaining two connected systems is real ongoing overhead that a lean team doesn't need to carry before the core media outlet itself is thriving.

Importantly, **this doesn't mean the idea is dead** — it's addressed directly in the roadmap below (Phase 2). It's just no longer wired into the day-to-day website.

8. Where This Is Headed

There's a long-term ambition behind this project: to become the go-to sports-tech company for Kenyan (and eventually African) sport — not just a media outlet, but the company that *everything else* in Kenyan sport eventually runs through. Several ideas toward that goal have been deliberately paused until the core media outlet (this website, with its shows running regularly) is solid and self-sustaining. Here's the order they're meant to happen in:

Phase 0 — Right now: get the core media outlet fully running

All six shows publishing on a regular schedule, real matching photos everywhere (three shows still need correct photos, per Section 6), and the Archive genuinely growing over time. One small addition still being considered: a lightweight way to post quick factual updates (like a confirmed transfer) without it becoming a busy news feed — still filed permanently into the Archive, just shorter and faster to produce than a full feature story.

Phase 1 — The cheapest next upgrades

An AI-assisted clip-making tool: automatically find the most shareable 30–75 second moments from full show recordings and turn them into ready-to-post social clips with captions. This directly supports the existing strategy of distributing the flagship show widely in short-form video, costs very little to build, and speeds up producing everyday content.

A small pilot with real athletes: use that same clip-making tool to create personal highlight packages for a handful of athletes already appearing on the shows, letting them post it under their own name. No cost either way at first — just testing whether there's real interest before building anything bigger.

Phase 2 — The data venture, reimaged

What used to be described as “a sports statistics database” has been reframed more ambitiously as a **scouting, agency, and information hub about players** — potentially useful for: clubs and agents

scouting talent, representing or brokering players directly (which connects back to Phase 1's athlete work), and simply being a trustworthy reference product that could be sold on its own, independent of the media outlet. This is intentionally being built as its own separate product with its own database — not wired back into The Sportscast website, at least not casually. The realistic starting point: pick one currently-undocumented competition and have journalists who are already covering it jot down basic structured facts (line-ups, scorers) as a natural side-effect of being there. This kind of thing only becomes valuable after a few years of accumulated data — it should start early, with the expectation of no real payoff for a while.

Phase 3 — Holding public money accountable

Tracking how public funds directed at sport are actually spent, and whether promised facilities and programs get delivered. This is one of the most original ideas on this list — almost nobody, anywhere, has solved this well, so doing it isn't catching up to a competitor, it's inventing a new category. The right way to start is *not* by building a tool or database first — it's by doing one real, well-researched investigative story. Only if that story turns up genuinely reusable, structured information should a recurring public tool be built around it. This is also the most sensitive item on the list, legally and reputationally, and deserves real editorial care.

Phase 4 — The actual end goal

Once the earlier phases are working *together* rather than as separate side-projects, the bigger picture comes into focus: a company that Kenyan sport genuinely runs on — known for its shows, holding data nobody else has, with real relationships directly with athletes, and trusted for holding public institutions accountable. Concretely, that could eventually include things like a verified public directory of Kenyan athletes that brands can use to sponsor them fairly and directly, or licensing the clip-making technology to other African media outlets.

One clear boundary worth keeping in mind: this company should deliberately avoid getting into physical tracking hardware/wearables, or into supplying live data feeds for sports betting, at least not casually. Both would turn this from a media-and-information company into a hardware company or a regulated-data-vendor company — a fundamentally different, harder business to run. If either ever becomes worth pursuing, it should be a deliberate, carefully-considered decision on its own, not something drifted into.

9. The Short Version, If You Only Remember One Thing

This is being run as a lean, founder-led media company, not a large, well-funded startup with a big team. Every decision behind how this website is built — the simple technology, the single content system instead of many complicated ones, cutting loose the separate player database — is optimized so that a very small team can hold the whole thing in their heads at once. Whoever works on this next should build in that same spirit: simple, understandable, and matched to the size of the team actually

running it, rather than over-engineering for a scale that doesn't exist yet.